

BACKGROUND GUIDE

DISEC

AI-CON 2026

Agenda:

*Countering the Threat Posed by Improvised Explosive Devices (IEDs).
Delegates address the proliferation and devastating impact of IEDs on
civilian populations and global security, crafting multilateral frameworks
for detection, prevention, and international cooperation.*

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Letter From the Executive Board

Greetings Delegates,

It is with profound honor and immense pleasure that we welcome you to the First Committee of the UNGA at AI CON 2026. As the Executive Board, we are dedicated to ensuring a seamless and enriching committee experience over three days of the conference.

Considering the technicality over the agenda, the Executive Board had drafted this Background Guide keeping in mind the need for the understanding of:

- i. Technicality,
- ii. Policy understanding, and
- iii. Relevancy.

Thus, the Board simply lays out a foundation for the delegates by giving them an idea over the agenda, and leaves it to the delegates to ideate over the aforesaid agenda. Thus, the Board refrains from leading the committee into any sense of direction and is curious to see what each delegate brings to the Committee sessions.

Understanding that, we urge you to approach this conference not as a zero-sum game but as a collaborative learning experience., thus, ensuring all delegates are held on an equal footing.

Additionally, please refer to the addendum attached to this letter for details on the nature of evidence required in this simulation.

The success of our committee depends on the active involvement of each delegate. We believe in your potential to excel and lead, whether you are a first-time participant or a seasoned veteran. We encourage you to speak and participate actively, as it would bring us immense satisfaction to see each delegate leave with greater knowledge and confidence than when they arrived.

With best wishes for a successful conference.

Executive Board of the UNGA - DISEC

Addendum - Standard Of Proof

There shall be broadly two categories of proof that shall be submitted: Conclusive and Rebuttable.

The following documents shall be acceptable as “proof” of a claim or allegation in the course of the proceedings:

1. UN Reports and News (Conclusive). This includes, but is not restricted to:
 - a. Reports of the UN Press;
 - b. Reports of the UN Organs and Agencies (UNSC, UNGA, UNESCO, etc.);
 - c. Reports of the Allied Agencies considered authoritative (World Bank Group (including IBRD, IDA, etc.), the IMF, the IAEA, the GCC, etc.)

2. Government and its Agencies (Conclusive to the extent of controversy): Reports of any government and its agencies shall be conclusive so far as its own initiatives, schemes, and achievements in a certain field are concerned. Anything event or claim in controversy or remaining disputed as of the date of the session is rebuttable.

Example: A news report from a state-sponsored news agency shall not be conclusive proof of the absence of any state-sponsored human rights violation or persecution.

3. News Sources (Rebuttable): Reports from Reuters, Al Jazeera, or BBC shall only be accepted to the extent that there is no better proof to the contrary which disproves the claims in their articles.

NOTE: A delegate shall be allowed to use the article as a reference but is not given the guarantee that the claims in such an article shall be treated as proof.

Introduction to the Committee

The First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, commonly referred to as the **Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC)**, serves as the principal deliberative forum of the United Nations for matters concerning international peace, security, arms control, and emerging threats to global stability. While traditionally associated with issues such as disarmament, non-proliferation, and conflict prevention, the Committee has progressively expanded its scope to address contemporary security challenges that transcend conventional military concerns.

Modern international security is increasingly influenced by economic interdependence, resource competition, environmental degradation, and the governance of strategic commodities. Natural resources, particularly those essential for industrial development and technological advancement, have become instruments of geopolitical influence. Consequently, disputes concerning access to, ownership of, and governance over these resources possess significant implications for regional stability and international peace.

Mining occupies a unique position within this discourse. Beyond serving as a source of economic development, mining provides the critical minerals required for renewable energy technologies, semiconductor manufacturing, advanced defence systems, telecommunications infrastructure, and modern transportation. As global demand for these resources continues to accelerate, mining operations increasingly extend across ecologically interconnected and politically sensitive regions, where extraction in one State frequently produces environmental, economic, and humanitarian consequences beyond its territorial borders.

Unlike traditional security threats, the instability generated by transboundary mining seldom arises from deliberate aggression. Rather, it emerges from structural deficiencies in governance, unequal participation in decision-making, fragmented regulatory oversight, and competing interpretations of sovereignty over shared natural systems. These conditions have transformed resource governance into an issue of international security, requiring cooperative multilateral solutions rather than purely domestic regulation.

Within this context, DISEC provides an appropriate forum for examining how transboundary mining influences interstate relations, regional stability, environmental security, and the evolving relationship between sovereign rights and collective international responsibility.

Understanding the Agenda

I. Introduction to Improvised Explosive Devices

An Improvised Explosive Device (IED) is a device constructed or adapted from available materials with the intention of causing an explosion. Unlike conventional military weapons, IEDs are not manufactured according to a single standard design. Their composition, method of deployment, and intended target can vary considerably.

This makes them particularly difficult to detect, regulate, and prevent. IEDs have been employed in armed conflicts, terrorist attacks, insurgencies, criminal activity, and other forms of violence. Their consequences extend well beyond the immediate explosion. Civilians may suffer death, serious injury, displacement, and psychological trauma, while roads, schools, hospitals, electricity networks, and other essential infrastructure may also be affected.

The international challenge arises partly from the accessibility and dual-use nature of many materials associated with IED construction. Certain components may have legitimate civilian, industrial, agricultural, or commercial purposes. Consequently, preventing their misuse requires more than simply restricting materials. Effective prevention may involve customs controls, information-sharing, technological detection, protection of critical infrastructure, public awareness, and cooperation between national authorities.

The problem may be understood through four interconnected stages:



For DISEC, the principal question is therefore not merely how States can respond after an IED attack, but how they can collectively reduce the possibility of such attacks occurring in the first place. Delegates must consider differing national capacities and security concerns while developing measures that are practical, proportionate, and capable of international implementation.

Chronology/ Historical Timeline

1. 19th–Early 20th Century: The Emergence of Improvised Explosives

The use of improvised explosive devices predates the modern terminology surrounding them. Explosives constructed outside conventional military systems were used by various armed and revolutionary groups during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Their emergence demonstrated an enduring feature of improvised weapons: relatively small quantities of explosive material could produce effects disproportionate to the resources required to deploy them.

2. 1930s–1940s: Explosives and Irregular Warfare

During the Second World War, improvised explosive devices became increasingly associated with irregular warfare. Resistance movements and military forces employed improvised charges for sabotage, particularly against transportation networks, military equipment, and infrastructure.

3. 1960s–1990s: Expansion Through Insurgencies and Terrorism

The use of IED-type devices expanded significantly during conflicts and insurgencies in different regions. Their relative adaptability made them attractive to groups lacking conventional military capabilities. During this period, bombing campaigns increasingly demonstrated that explosive devices could be used not only against military targets but also against public spaces and civilian populations.

4. 1990s–2001: Growing International Security Concern

The increasing use of terrorist bombings placed explosive devices firmly within the international counter-terrorism agenda. States began strengthening legislation concerning explosives, improving intelligence cooperation, and developing specialised techniques for bomb detection and forensic investigation.

5. 2001–2010s: IEDs as a Major Conflict Threat

Following the conflicts in Afghanistan and Iraq, IEDs became one of the most significant threats faced by military personnel and civilians in conflict-affected areas. International organisations and States invested heavily in counter-IED technologies, bomb-disposal capabilities, intelligence-sharing, and training.

The experience also demonstrated that the consequences of IEDs are not confined to the battlefield. Civilians, humanitarian workers, infrastructure, and economic activity can all be affected.

6. 2010s–Present: From Battlefield Threat to Transnational Security Challenge

The proliferation of terrorist organisations and armed groups across different regions has further internationalised the problem. IEDs continue to be employed in conflicts and terrorist attacks, while advances in commercially available technology have created new challenges for authorities.

International responses have consequently expanded beyond military countermeasures. Contemporary approaches increasingly involve border management, control of precursor materials, international information-sharing, forensic cooperation, protection of critical infrastructure, technological innovation, and assistance to States with limited counter-IED capabilities.

7. The Present Challenge

Today, the central issue before the international community is how to prevent the misuse of legitimate technologies and materials without unnecessarily obstructing lawful civilian activity. DISEC must therefore approach IEDs as a multidimensional security problem involving prevention, law enforcement, technology, international cooperation, humanitarian protection, and national capacity.

For delegates, understanding this history is important because the agenda is not simply about responding to explosions. It is about identifying how and why the threat develops, where international cooperation can intervene, and what responsibilities States should undertake collectively.

Understanding IEDs Better

1. IEDs are not a single category of weapon

A useful starting point is that an IED is better understood as a category of improvised explosive weaponry, rather than as one particular type of bomb.

Academic literature identifies substantial variation in the way IEDs are designed and employed. They may be used against military personnel, civilians, infrastructure, vehicles or public spaces, and their characteristics can differ according to the conflict environment, resources available to the perpetrator and intended effect.

An academic work had been published, it described IEDs as encompassing a broad range of devices, from relatively rudimentary homemade explosives to more sophisticated systems. Their study discusses several broad forms encountered in conflict environments, including roadside explosive devices, blast mines, explosively formed projectile devices and suicide bombings.¹

2. The defining characteristic is their "improvised" nature

IEDs are generally produced outside conventional government-controlled weapons manufacturing systems. This creates a fundamental difference between IEDs and conventional arms-control problems.

The United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs observes that IED production occurs outside government controls. Consequently, a traditional arms-control model—where States regulate the manufacture, transfer and use of weapons by governments—cannot by itself adequately address IED proliferation.

This is one of the most important conceptual points for DISEC:

¹ A Ramasamy, AM Hill and JC Clasper, 'Improvised Explosive Devices: Pathophysiology, Injury Profiles and Current Medical Management' (2009) 155 *Journal of the Royal Army Medical Corps* 265.

IED proliferation is not simply an arms-transfer problem. It is also a materials, governance, intelligence, law-enforcement and supply-chain problem.

This explains why the international response has increasingly moved towards cooperation between different governmental sectors rather than treating the issue exclusively as a military matter.²

3. The "dual-use" problem

One of the more important and less obvious aspects of IED policy is the dual-use nature of many materials. Dual-use means that something can have a legitimate civilian purpose while also potentially being misused for harmful purposes.

A State cannot simply prohibit every material that could potentially be diverted for the production of an explosive device because many such materials have legitimate industrial, agricultural, commercial or scientific uses.

An academic work examines this problem specifically in relation to explosive chemical precursors. Their research argues for improved risk-management systems capable of identifying materials requiring greater scrutiny while recognising that regulation must operate within legitimate commercial markets.³

A legitimate thought arises:

How can States prevent diversion without unnecessarily restricting legitimate economic activity?

² United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, 'Improvised Explosive Devices' (UNODA) <https://www.unoda.org/en/our-work/conventional-arms/improvised-explosive-devices>

³ Gareth Collett and others, 'The Use of a Predictive Threat Analysis to Propose Revisions to Existing Risk Assessments for Precursor Chemicals Used in the Manufacture of Home-Made Explosives (HME)' (2021) 7 *Heliyon* e08343 <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2021.e08343>.

4. IEDs involve a "network", not merely a device

A particularly useful development in contemporary C-IED research is the idea of an IED network.

➔ The device itself is only one part of a much larger system.

Research published in *Security Journal* describes an IED network as interconnected human and material nodes associated with the diversion of commodities and other activities connected to IED production.⁴

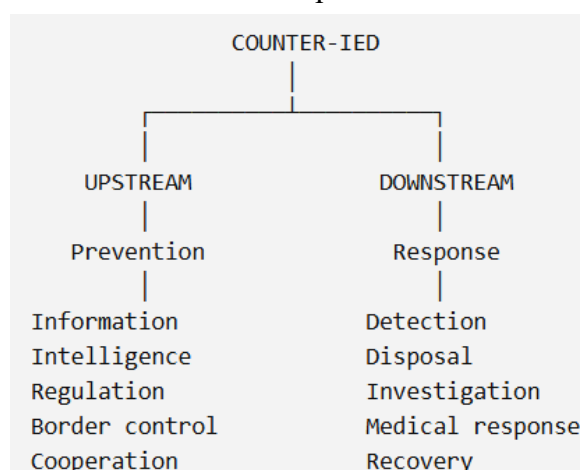
5. Prevention begins before the device exists

One of the strongest ideas emerging from C-IED research is the distinction between upstream and downstream responses.

UNIDIR's Counter-IED Capability Maturity Model divides counter-IED capability into:

- Upstream measures: Measures intended to prevent an IED incident from occurring.
- Downstream measures: Measures intended to respond to or mitigate an IED incident once it occurs.⁵

The below model makes an important observation: greater effectiveness in upstream prevention can reduce the burden placed on downstream responses.



Note:
Image generated through
the ChatGPT application.

⁴ Gareth Collett and others, 'Introducing Bayesian Belief Updating as a Method to Counter Improvised Explosive Devices: A Qualitative Case Study on Identifying Human Behaviours Associated with Explosive Chemical Precursor Diversion' (2024) 37 *Security Journal* 793 <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41284-023-00395-0>.

⁵ Bob Seddon and Alfredo Malaret Baldo, *Counter-IED Capability Maturity Model and Self-Assessment Tool* (UNIDIR 2020) <https://doi.org/10.37559/CAAP/20/ASC/04>

6. IEDs as a Forensic Problem

An Improvised Explosive Device (IED) presents a distinctive forensic problem because the explosion that destroys the device does not necessarily destroy all evidence capable of identifying its origin or the persons involved. The post-blast scene may retain fragments, biological material, fingerprints and other trace evidence that can assist investigators in reconstructing the event and establishing connections between individuals and the device. Research has demonstrated that latent fingerprints and touch DNA can, in some circumstances, survive both neutralisation procedures and detonation, permitting comparison and individualisation even when only very small quantities of evidence remain.⁶

This is particularly significant because IEDs are frequently assembled from ordinary, commercially available objects. Consequently, forensic examination is not confined to identifying an explosive substance; it may involve examining the remnants of the device and determining what those remnants can reveal about its handling and provenance. Recent research further demonstrates that DNA may remain recoverable from detonated IED components, although its quantity and analytical value can be affected by the intensity of the explosion, the material examined and the location of the biological trace.⁷

⁶ N Vanderheyden and others, 'Survival of forensic trace evidence on improvised explosive devices: perspectives on individualisation' (2020) 10 *Scientific Reports* 12813 <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-020-69385-1>

⁷ GA Salih and others, 'Evaluation of DNA recovery from improvised explosive device components after detonations' (2026) 82 *Forensic Science International: Genetics* 103418 <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.fsigen.2025.103418>

Questions a Resolution Must Answer

For this simulation, no QARMA will be provided. The discussion, deliberation and solutions which would ideally be incorporated in the final document must be of open ended in structure; which leaves space for discussion of all without directing the committee in any manner to a particular end goal.

References/ Relevant Documents

- Counter-IED Capability Maturity Model and Self-Assessment Tool: [UNIDIR — Full PDF](#)
- Addressing Improvised Explosive Devices: Options and Opportunities to Better Utilize UN Processes and Actors: [UNIDIR — Full publication and PDF](#)
- Examining the Roles, Responsibilities and Potential Contributions of Private Sector Industry Actors in Stemming the Flow of IEDs and Related Materials: [UNIDIR — Full publication and PDF](#)
- Countering the Threat Posed by Improvised Explosive Devices (2024): [United Nations Digital Library — PDF](#)
- Countering the Threat Posed by Improvised Explosive Devices (2020): [United Nations Digital Library — PDF](#)
- Countering the Threat Posed by Improvised Explosive Devices (2018): [United Nations Digital Library — PDF](#)
- Improvised Explosive Devices: [United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs \(UNODA\)](#)
- Preventing Terrorists from Acquiring Weapons — Technical Guidelines: [United Nations Counter-Terrorism Committee Executive Directorate — PDF](#)
- Evaluation of DNA Recovery from Improvised Explosive Device Components after Detonations: [Forensic Science International: Genetics — Open Access](#)
- Detection and Localization of Improvised Explosive Devices Based on 3-Axis Magnetic Sensor Array System: [Procedia Engineering — Open Access](#)